

Tool. Database of Electric lets you operate a number of synthesis and analysis tools, acting like an operating system and smoothly overseeing the tool's operations. The tools can operate incrementally or in batches, with the database managing inter-operation between these and the user interface, also with scope for undoing any incorrect tool activity.

Manage smart, use effectively

You just saw how you can use Electric to your benefit to create amazing chips and get these working on your hardware setup. But during the design stage, each design being pretty complex, might involve multiple people handling it. Electric is designed keeping this factor in mind and has a stable project management in place.

The system allows you to share the circuit library. To edit any

A snapshot of Electric's capabilities

- Design rule checking
- Electrical rule checking
- Simulation and simulation interface (many options)
- Generation (ROMs, PLAs, Pad Frames, etc)
- Compaction
- Routing
- VHDL compilation
- Silicon compilation
- Network consistency checking (LVS)
- Logical effort analysis
- Project management

cell, you have to check out that particular cell, make the changes and check the cell back in. This checking-out process is handled beautifully by the tool to avoid unwanted problems. Each time a cell is checked out, other users are prevented from making changes to the same. If the changes tend

to affect cells other than just the checked-out cell, the detail is flagged and a warning is issued if multiple users check out hierarchically-related cells.

Nothing to stop you from getting electrically attracted

The opinion one gets on seeing Electric is that the tool is thoughtfully put together. Each aspect of the software seems to have a valid reasoning behind it. The only catch is that the tool needs getting used to, as the user interface and tool design methodology are unlike most integrated circuit design tools. The software is currently under GNU project (www.gnu.org/software/electric) and distributed as free and open source software. **EFY**

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